

Florida Keys Fishing Guide

563+ GPS Spots: Key Largo to Key West

Patch Reefs, Bridges, Flats, Offshore Humps, and Everything Between

FloridaFishingMaps.com | support@floridafishingmaps.com

Introduction

The Florida Keys are 125 miles of fishing paradise strung across the only tropical waters in the continental United States. From the patch reefs of Key Largo to the backcountry flats of Key West, the Keys offer fishing diversity that no other destination in North America can match. Flats fishing for permit and bonefish. Patch reef fishing for yellowtail and mutton snapper. Bridge fishing for tarpon. Offshore humps for tuna and wahoo. Backcountry for everything from snook to barracuda.

This guide covers 563+ GPS-verified fishing spots spanning the entire island chain. Whether you trailer your boat to Islamorada and fish the backcountry or run offshore from Marathon to the deep humps, these coordinates put you on productive structure immediately -- no guesswork, no searching, no wasted fuel.

The Keys Fishing Zones

Upper Keys: Key Largo to Islamorada (MM 106 to MM 73)

The Upper Keys sit along the only section of the Florida Reef Tract that supports true coral growth in North American waters. The reef system here is more developed than anywhere else in the Keys, with massive brain corals, elkhorn formations, and spur-and-groove reef structure extending from just offshore out to the reef wall.

Key Largo Highlights:

- Pennekamp Reef system (no-take zones clearly marked in your GPS file -- avoid these)
- Patch reefs in 15-35 feet holding yellowtail, mangrove snapper, hogfish
- Elbow Reef, French Reef, Molasses Reef -- the famous reef line in 25-40 feet
- Deep wrecks: The Spiegel Grove (130 feet), USCGC Duane (120 feet), Bibb (130 feet)
- Offshore humps and ledges in 200-400 feet

Islamorada Highlights:

- Alligator Reef Light and surrounding structure
- Tennessee Reef -- massive flat reef in 20-30 feet loaded with yellowtail
- The Islamorada Hump (East Hump) -- deep offshore structure in 600-800 feet
- Backcountry: Florida Bay flats, Snake Creek, Lignumvitae Channel
- Indian Key Channel and surrounding flats for permit and bonefish
- Whale Harbor Channel and bridgeside structure

Middle Keys: Long Key to the Seven Mile Bridge (MM 73 to MM 40)

The Middle Keys are defined by Marathon and the famous bridges. The Old Seven Mile Bridge (now partially demolished but with pilings remaining) created one of the most iconic bridge fishing destinations in the world. Marathon sits at the geographic center of the Keys and provides access to both the Gulf (backcountry, flats) and the Atlantic (reef, offshore).

Marathon Highlights:

- The Seven Mile Bridge rubble and remaining pilings -- tarpon alley in spring
- Marathon Humps (aka "The Humps"): Western Hump in 450-500 feet and Eastern Hump in 380-480 feet. These are the most famous offshore structures in the Keys.
- Tom's Ledge and surrounding reef in 60-110 feet
- Sombrero Reef Light and the reef line in 20-35 feet
- Marathon backcountry: Boot Key Harbor, Sister's Creek, Vaca Key flats
- Content Keys and the flats west of Marathon (permit, bonefish, tarpon)

Lower Keys: Big Pine Key to Key West (MM 40 to MM 0)

The Lower Keys offer the best backcountry fishing in the island chain. The flats spread out wider here, the water is clearer, and the fishing pressure drops off substantially compared to Islamorada and Marathon. Key West itself is a deepwater port with quick access to the Gulf Stream and the reef.

Lower Keys Highlights:

- Looe Key Reef -- one of the healthiest reef sections in the Keys
- The 409 Hump (Western Dry Rocks area) -- deep offshore structure
- Key West backcountry: Lakes Passage, Boca Chica Channel, Content Keys
- The Marquesas (30 miles west of Key West) -- pristine flats, permit capital
- Dry Tortugas proximity -- 70 miles from Key West, legendary grouper and snapper fishing
- Key West harbor and channel markers -- tarpon staging areas in spring
- Sand Key and Rock Key reef line
- Western Sambo Reef and the ledges offshore

Target Species: Keys Edition

Yellowtail Snapper (Year-round, Best: October through April)

Yellowtail are the bread-and-butter fish of the Keys. They are abundant, aggressive feeders, excellent table fare, and fun on light tackle. The Keys' patch reef system holds more yellowtail per square mile than anywhere else in the Atlantic.

Where: Every patch reef, hard-bottom spot, and ledge in your GPS package from 15 to 120 feet holds yellowtail. The densest concentrations are on the patch reefs in 18-35 feet scattered between the shoreline and the main reef line. Your GPS file marks dozens of these patch reefs -- they are often small (the size of a house) and invisible on standard charts without GPS numbers.

How: Anchor up-current of the patch reef and deploy a chum bag (frozen glass minnow/oat/sand mixture, or Key-brand chum blocks). Let the chum drift back over the reef. Use 15-20 pound fluorocarbon leader, size 1 to 1/0 hooks, and small pieces of ballyhoo, shrimp, or squid for bait. The key to big yellowtails is using light leader -- they have sharp eyes and will refuse heavy tackle. For trophy fish (5+ pounds), fish at night on the deeper reefs (60-100 feet) with live pilchards in a chum slick.

Regulations: Check FWC for current bag limits. As of this writing, the bag limit is 10 per person per day in Atlantic federal waters with a 12-inch minimum.

Grouper Species

Black Grouper: Found on deeper reefs, wrecks, and ledges in 80-200+ feet. The Keys produce trophy blacks, especially around the deep wrecks like the Spiegel Grove and Duane. Live blue runners or pinfish on heavy knocker rigs near structure. Season: May 1 through December 31 in Atlantic federal waters.

Red Grouper: More common on lower-profile structure in 60-150 feet. Live or cut bait on a knocker rig or chicken rig. Reds are slightly less structure-oriented than blacks and are often caught over scattered rock and rubble bottoms.

Mutton Snapper (often grouped with reef fish): Keys mutton fishing is legendary during the May/June full moon spawns. Fish concentrate on specific reef edges in 40-80 feet and feed aggressively. The GPS spots labeled "Mutton Ledge" in your file are exactly where to be during the spawn.

Nassau Grouper: CLOSED to harvest. If you catch one (tan/brown with dark vertical bars and a distinctive eye stripe), release it immediately. They are protected and critically important to reef recovery.

Hogfish (Year-round, Best: November through April)

The Keys produce some of the best hogfish fishing in Florida. These reef-dwelling wrasse live on hard bottom and patch reefs in 15-60 feet, where they root around for crabs, urchins, and small crustaceans. They are arguably the best-eating fish in the ocean -- sweet, white, lobster-like flesh.

Where: Patch reefs and scattered hard bottom in 15-45 feet. Look for spots in your GPS file marked on isolated reef patches surrounded by sand. Hogfish prefer areas with gorgonians (sea fans) and low-profile coral rubble.

How: Very light tackle -- 10-15 pound fluorocarbon, a small knocker rig with a 1/0 to 2/0 hook, and a live shrimp. Drop the bait directly on the patch reef and keep it there. Hogfish are nibblers -- they bite differently from snapper. You will feel small taps before the take. Patience is key. They are also excellent spearfishing targets for those who dive.

Permit (Year-round, Best: March through July)

The Keys are the permit capital of the world. These silver, broad-bodied members of the jack family cruise the flats in water sometimes less than two feet deep, and they are one of the most challenging fish to hook on fly or light tackle. A permit on fly is considered one of the grand slams of saltwater fly fishing.

Where: Flats throughout the Keys hold permit, but the most consistent fisheries are:

- Content Keys (between Marathon and Big Pine)
- Islamorada ocean-side flats and channels
- Boca Grande Channel area (Lower Keys)
- The Marquesas Keys (remote, pristine, legendary)
- Wreck patches and channel edges -- permit also stage around structure

How: Sight-fishing on the flats: pole the skiff across clean sand and turtle grass flats, looking for the black-tipped tails or dark shapes of feeding permit. Present a live crab (pass crab, blue crab) on a 2/0 hook with 20-pound fluorocarbon leader, pitched 5-10 feet in front of the fish. On fly, use a merkin-style crab pattern or EP Permit Crab in tan/olive on a size 2 to 1/0 hook.

Permit also feed around wrecks and bridges. Dropping a live crab near bridge pilings on the falling tide with medium spinning tackle produces permit without the skinny-water sight-fishing difficulty.

Tarpon (Peak: March through July)

The Keys spring tarpon migration is one of the greatest spectacles in sportfishing. Fish from 60 to 200 pounds pour through the channels, under the bridges, and along the oceanside flats from March through July, with peak numbers in May and June.

Where:

- Bahia Honda Bridge -- the most famous tarpon bridge in the world
- Seven Mile Bridge (remaining pilings and channel)
- Long Key Bridge and Channel 2/Channel 5
- Key West harbor and Northwest Channel
- Islamorada oceanside: bridge channels and flats
- Content Keys passes on the falling tide

How: Bridge fishing: anchor up-current of a bridge on the outgoing tide and drift live mullet, crabs, or pinfish under the bridge where tarpon stage in the current shadow. Use 60-80 pound spinning or conventional tackle with a 80-100 pound fluorocarbon leader.

Flats/channel fishing: sight-cast to rolling or laid-up tarpon in channels and on flats. Live mullet, crabs, or large Vudu shrimp-style soft plastics. On fly, the classic tarpon setup is a 12-weight rod with an intermediate or floating line and a 3/0 to 4/0 Tarpon Toad, Black Death, or Cockroach pattern.

Bonefish (Year-round, Best: October through May)

The Keys hold the only significant bonefish population in the continental US. Fish from 3 to 12+ pounds cruise the turtle grass and sand flats, feeding on shrimp, crabs, and worms. A bonefish on fly is an iconic Keys experience.

Where: Islamorada ocean-side flats, Key Largo bayside, Lower Keys (Sugarloaf, Summerland, Big Pine), Content Keys. The best bonefish flats are hard-bottom or mixed grass/sand with clear water and gentle tidal flow.

How: Sight-fishing from a poled skiff. Look for nervous water, muds (cloudy patches from feeding fish), or tailing fish on low tides. Present a live shrimp on a 10-pound fluorocarbon leader with a small split shot, or a Gotcha/Crazy Charlie fly on an 8-weight rod. The Keys bonefishing community practices strict catch-and-release.

Offshore: Mahi, Wahoo, Tuna, Sailfish

The Marathon Humps are the crown jewels of Keys offshore fishing. Located roughly 25 miles south of Marathon in the Straits of Florida, the Western Hump rises from 1,000+ feet to approximately 480 feet, and the Eastern Hump rises to about 380 feet. These underwater mountains concentrate baitfish, yellowfin tuna, blackfin tuna, wahoo, and mahi in staggering numbers during the right conditions.

The 409 Hump (Lower Keys) is another deep-water seamount that produces yellowfin tuna, wahoo, and billfish. Located south-southwest of Key West in deep water.

Islamorada Hump (East Hump): Deep structure east of Islamorada that produces tuna and swordfish.

How to fish the humps: Run out on calm days (these are 20-30 mile runs from shore). Troll along the edges of the humps with skirted ballyhoo, Ilander lures, and wahoo bombs at 8-12 knots. When you mark fish on the hump, switch to vertical jigging with butterfly jigs or drop live baits. Chunking with cut bonito or blackfin attracts yellowfin to the surface. Bring enough fuel for the long run and always check the weather forecast twice before committing to a hump trip.

Bridge Fishing in the Keys

The Keys' bridges are fishing structures without equal. The old bridges (many now demolished or converted to pedestrian bridges) created miles of concrete pilings that attract and hold massive quantities of fish. Even the modern bridges fish well on tide changes.

Bridge Fishing Fundamentals

Tide is everything. Bridge fishing is entirely tide-dependent. The moving water funnels bait through the pilings, and predators stage in the current shadows waiting to ambush. The best bite is typically the last two hours of the outgoing tide and the first hour of the incoming.

Position: Anchor up-current of the bridge so your bait drifts naturally toward the pilings. Position far enough away that your anchor line does not swing your boat into the bridge on a tide shift.

Tackle: Medium-heavy spinning or conventional gear. 40-60 pound braid main line, 40-60 pound fluorocarbon leader. For tarpon and big sharks, step up to 80-pound class.

What Lives Under Keys Bridges

- Tarpon (spring migration, 60-200 pounds)
- Snook (year-round, concentrated in winter)
- Goliath grouper (year-round, catch and release only)
- Mangrove snapper (year-round, excellent at night)
- Yellowtail snapper (year-round on deeper bridge channels)
- Permit (stage around pilings, especially on falling tide)
- Barracuda (year-round residents)
- Cobia (winter, cruising bridge shadows)
- Nurse sharks and bull sharks (year-round)
- Spiny lobster (in season, around pilings)

Patch Reef Fishing: The Keys' Secret Weapon

Most visitors to the Keys head straight to the main reef line or the offshore humps and ignore the patch reefs. This is a mistake. The hundreds of small patch reefs scattered between the shoreline and the outer reef in 12-40 feet of water hold tremendous quantities of fish and are often lightly pressured because they are

invisible without GPS coordinates.

A typical Keys patch reef is a limestone mound covered in coral, sponges, and sea fans, rising 3-10 feet off the surrounding sand bottom. It might be the size of a living room or the size of a football field. Without GPS numbers, you would never know it was there -- your depthfinder shows a slight rise and then it is gone.

How to Fish Patch Reefs

1. **Approach quietly.** In 15-25 feet of clear water, fish can see and hear your boat. Idle up to within 100 yards, then shut down and drift or use your trolling motor to position.
2. **Anchor up-current.** Drop anchor 50-75 feet up-current of the patch reef. Your chum will drift directly over the structure.
3. **Deploy chum immediately.** A chum bag (frozen block or mesh bag of glass minnows and oats) goes over the side the moment you anchor. Give it 10-15 minutes to create a slick before fishing.
4. **Light tackle only.** 15-20 pound fluorocarbon leader maximum for yellowtail. Heavier leader catches fewer fish in clear shallow water. Size 1 to 1/0 hooks with small baits.
5. **Work the depth column.** Yellowtails rise in the chum slick and feed at various depths. Start at the bottom and progressively fish shallower as the chum slick develops. The biggest yellowtails often hang 10-15 feet down while the small ones are at the surface.

Backcountry and Flats Fishing

Florida Bay and the Gulf Side

The backcountry refers to the Gulf side of the Keys -- the vast, shallow Florida Bay system stretching from Key Largo to Key West. This is a maze of flats, channels, basins, and mangrove islands that holds a completely different fishery from the Atlantic side.

Target Species in the Backcountry:

- Bonefish (flats)
- Permit (channels and edges)
- Tarpon (basins and channels, especially spring)
- Snook (mangrove shorelines, docks)
- Redfish (mangrove edges, mud flats)
- Spotted seatrout (grass flats)
- Sharks (everywhere -- lemons, blacktips, bulls, bonnetheads)
- Jack crevalle (channels and flats)
- Barracuda (flats and channels)

Navigation Warning: The backcountry is extremely shallow. Outside marked channels, depths of 1-3 feet are common across vast areas. Running aground is not a question of "if" but "when" if you do not know the water. Use the GPS waypoints for channel routes and stick to marked paths until you learn the area. A shallow-draft skiff or flats boat (drafts under 12 inches) is the proper tool for backcountry exploration.

Key Flats Fishing Areas in Your GPS Package

Islamorada Backcountry: Shell Key Basin, Buchanan Bank, Tern Key, Sandy Key, Peterson Keys. Access via Whale Harbor Channel or Indian Key Channel to Snake Creek and then into Florida Bay.

Marathon Backcountry: Content Keys, East Content Key flats, Boot Key Channel approach, Seven Mile Bridge Gulf-side flats. Access via Boot Key Harbor or under the Seven Mile Bridge on the Gulf side.

Lower Keys Backcountry: Boca Chica Channel, Shark Key Basin, Saddlebunch Keys, Content Keys (south), Lakes Passage, Waltz Key Basin. Access via multiple channels from Big Pine Key south.

Tides and Moon Phases in the Keys

Why Tides Matter More Here

The Keys sit between the Atlantic Ocean and the Gulf of Mexico, and tidal patterns are unusual compared to the mainland. Many areas of the Keys experience a "mixed semi-diurnal" tide -- two highs and two lows per day, but of unequal height and duration. The Gulf side (backcountry) often has a slower, more subtle tide change than the ocean side.

General Rules:

- Reef fishing: Best on slack tide or slow current (baits stay in the strike zone)
- Bridge fishing: Best on strong current, especially outgoing tide
- Flats fishing: Best on incoming tide (fish move onto flats to feed)
- Channel fishing: Best on outgoing tide (bait flushes through channels)
- Offshore humps: Current flow over the hump matters more than tide direction

Moon Phase Effects

Full Moon: Triggers mutton snapper spawning (May/June). Stronger tides mean more water movement through bridges and channels -- tarpon fishing often peaks 2-3 days before and after the full moon. Night reef fishing for yellowtail and mangrove snapper is best during the full moon when fish feed all night.

New Moon: Darker nights push fish to feed more during dawn and dusk. Offshore fishing for pelagics is often best around the new moon -- baitfish are more concentrated and predators hunt more actively without moonlight.

Quarter Moons: Moderate tides. Good all-around fishing. Many experienced Keys guides prefer the quarter moon phases because conditions are moderate and predictable.

Seasonal Patterns in the Keys

Winter (December through February)

The best all-around fishing season in the Keys. Water temperatures in the 70-75 degree range bring peak activity across most species.

- Yellowtail snapper: Peak numbers, aggressive feeding
- Hogfish: Active on patch reefs in 15-40 feet
- Kingfish: Migrating through, especially Upper Keys

- Sailfish: Working the reef edge and Gulf Stream
- Cobia: Following rays along reef edges and channels
- Bonefish: Good numbers on flats, especially Lower Keys
- Grouper: CLOSED in Atlantic federal waters (Jan 1 - April 30)

Spring (March through May)

The transition season brings tarpon, permit, and the mutton spawn.

- Tarpon: Migration begins in March, peaks in May
- Permit: Spawning aggregations on wrecks and edges
- Mutton Snapper: Full moon spawns in May and June -- legendary fishing
- Mahi: Showing up offshore as water warms
- Yellowtail: Still good through April, tapering in May
- Lobster season closes March 31

Summer (June through August)

Hot, calm, and productive offshore. Less comfortable inshore.

- Tarpon: Still present through June, tapering in July
- Mahi: Peak offshore, especially around the humps
- Tuna: Yellowfin and blackfin on the Marathon Humps
- Mutton: June full moon spawn continuation
- Mangrove snapper: Spawning aggregations on reefs and wrecks
- Lobster mini-season: Last consecutive Wednesday/Thursday in July

Fall (September through November)

The overlooked season. Fewer boats, excellent fishing as water cools.

- Yellowtail: Picking back up as water cools into the 70s
- Hogfish: Returning to shallower patch reefs
- Kingfish: Early arrivals in November
- Bonefish: Excellent on the flats, lower pressure
- Grouper season: Opens May 1, still going strong
- Lobster: Regular season runs August through March
- Wahoo: Picking up offshore in November

FWC Regulation Highlights (Verify Current Rules at MyFWC.com)

The Florida Keys span multiple regulatory zones. You may be in state waters, Atlantic federal waters, or Gulf federal waters depending on your exact position. Rules differ between zones.

Critical distinctions:

- The Keys are split into Atlantic (ocean side) and Gulf (bay side) regulations
- Federal waters begin 3 miles offshore in the Atlantic, 9 miles in the Gulf
- Sanctuary zones: The Florida Keys National Marine Sanctuary includes numerous no-take zones (Sanctuary Preservation Areas). These are marked in your GPS file. Do NOT fish in these areas.
- Lobster rules differ between the Keys and the rest of Florida

Always verify before you fish. Regulations change frequently. Download the Fish Rules app or visit MyFWC.com for current bag limits, size limits, and season dates. A federal HMS (Highly Migratory Species) permit is required for billfish, swordfish, and tunas.

Making the Most of 563+ Spots

Trip Planning Strategy

1. **Pick your zone.** If you are staying in Islamorada, focus on the Upper Keys spots. If you are in Marathon, focus on the Middle Keys. Do not try to cover the entire chain in one trip.
2. **Match conditions to spots.** Calm days: hit the offshore humps or run to the outer reef. Windy days: fish the backcountry (Gulf side) which is protected from east winds, or hit the bridges.
3. **Tide-match your spot selection.** Check the tide chart the night before and pick spots that fish best on the tides available during your fishing window.
4. **Have a primary and backup plan.** Keys weather is generally good, but winds can shift your options quickly. Always have an inside (protected) option ready if conditions blow out your first choice.
5. **Layer your spots.** Run to your farthest spot first while conditions are calm and fuel is full. Fish your way back toward the dock, hitting closer spots as the day goes on. This way, if weather deteriorates or you have a mechanical issue, you are already heading home.

Navigation Safety in the Keys

The Keys present unique navigation challenges:

- **Shallow water everywhere.** Outside marked channels, depths can be 1-3 feet with no warning on standard charts. Trust your GPS waypoints for safe routes and do not cut corners.
- **Coral heads.** Submerged coral heads can be invisible in poor light conditions. If you are running in unfamiliar water, slow down and post a lookout on the bow.
- **Crab trap floats.** The Keys are littered with crab and lobster trap floats. Running over a trap line can disable your engine. Maintain a constant watch, especially in the backcountry.
- **Marine sanctuary zones.** No-anchor zones, no-take zones, and speed zones are scattered throughout the Keys. Know where they are (they are marked in your GPS file) and respect them. Fines are severe.
- **Night navigation.** Avoid running in the backcountry at night unless you know the water intimately. Even with GPS, floating debris, unmarked pilings, and trap floats make night running dangerous.

Final Thoughts

The Florida Keys are a lifetime fishery. Anglers who have fished these waters for decades still discover new spots, learn new patterns, and catch fish they have never seen before. Your 563+ GPS waypoints are a massive head start, but they are not the end of the journey. Use them as a foundation, build on them with your own experience, and respect the resource that makes the Keys the fishing destination it is.

The reef system is fragile. The flats are sensitive to prop scarring. The fish populations depend on responsible harvest. Practice catch and release on all billfish and tarpon. Keep only what you will eat. Handle fish quickly and release them properly. The Keys' fishing future depends on every angler who wets a line here.

Tight lines from mile marker zero to Key Largo.

FloridaFishingMaps.com support@floridafishingmaps.com | www.floridafishingmaps.com

DISCLAIMER: GPS coordinates are approximate and provided for recreational fishing purposes only. They are not a substitute for proper navigation charts and safe boating practices. The Florida Keys National Marine Sanctuary contains numerous restricted zones -- it is your responsibility to know their boundaries. Fishing regulations change frequently -- verify current FWC rules before fishing. These files are licensed for personal use by the original purchaser only.